

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Energy and Utilities English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For utility operations staff, energy project managers, grid planners, field supervisors, regulatory affairs teams, renewable-energy developers, customer operations teams, and infrastructure leaders.

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Grid Reliability and Outage Response

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

02 Safety, Field Work, and Switching

Clarify missing information before responding.

03 Regulatory Affairs and Rate Cases

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

04 Renewables Integration and Interconnection

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

05 Asset Management and Maintenance

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

06 Emergency Preparedness and Storm Response

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

07 Customer Programs and Energy Efficiency

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

08 Executive Reliability and Investment Updates

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Grid Reliability and Outage Response

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

CASE

An outage update lists an affected area but the restoration estimate is still under assessment. A draft message gives a firm time.

Teach this move

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Vocabulary to check: reliability, feeder, restoration, critical customer.

Model response

The affected area is identified, but restoration timing is still being assessed. I'll state what is confirmed and when customers should expect the next update rather than promise an unverified time.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Second-round challenge

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Language-check answers

1. C - The team has completed the review. 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.
2. B - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it. This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

05 • Conversations

1. Restoration time remains under assessment - Fictional outage-communications exercise: an affected area is identified, but the restoration estimate is still being assessed. No operating instructions are given.
2. Some streets restored, others still affected - Separate fictional case: service restoration is confirmed for Oak Street, while adjacent Pine Street remains affected; no cause or completion time is supplied.

3. Reports received are not repairs completed - Separate fictional service-desk case: twenty outage reports have been logged and grouped for review; field assessment remains pending.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The status map has not refreshed

A fictional operations update confirms restoration in Zone A, but the public map still displays an outage there. Zone B remains affected. Discuss the current status and who checks the map update; no restoration time is supplied for Zone B.

Role A: Communications coordinator: separate the verified service status from the display discrepancy.

Role B: Customer-service lead: ask what staff should say about each zone.

Possible opening: Zone A is confirmed restored, but the map has not reflected that update; Zone B remains affected.

Success checks

- Preserve the different zone statuses.
- Identify the map discrepancy separately.
- Assign a display-status check without promising Zone B restoration.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to announce that both zones are restored to simplify the message.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Safety, Field Work, and Switching

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

During a language simulation, two documents use different equipment identifiers for a field task. Only authorized procedures govern the actual work.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: switching order, lockout, clearance, energize.

Model response

The equipment identifiers do not match. Please have the authorized team resolve the discrepancy using the approved procedure. I will repeat the identifiers clearly to confirm that we are discussing the same equipment.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. B - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. A - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. Two identifiers for the same field request - Fictional language simulation: a field request names equipment E12 while its accompanying document names E21. Actual work follows authorized procedures; no switching steps are provided.
2. Which document does released refer to? - Separate fictional administrative exercise: an email says released without identifying whether it refers to a document or an operational clearance.

3. A copied order lacks its revision - Separate fictional coordination exercise: a copied switching-order cover sheet has no revision identifier; the complete approved order is unavailable in the conversation.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A site nickname obscures the reference

In a fictional field-planning exercise, a message refers to the old yard unit, but the formal equipment identifier is absent. No operational status is known. Ask for the verified reference rather than interpreting the nickname.

Role A: Planning coordinator: request the formal identifier and approved source.

Role B: Operations liaison: acknowledge the missing information and seek authorized clarification.

Possible opening: Could you confirm the formal equipment identifier behind the phrase old yard unit?

Success checks

- Distinguish a nickname from a verified identifier.
- Request the approved source.
- Avoid giving switching, lockout, or clearance instructions.

Add a complication: A colleague offers a remembered identifier but cannot verify it.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Regulatory Affairs and Rate Cases

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

A customer sees a proposed rate adjustment and assumes it is already in effect. The notice describes a proposal under review.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: rate case, tariff, prudence, customer impact.

Model response

The notice describes a proposed adjustment, not a change already in effect. Let me show you the stated review process and where to find the current applicable tariff information.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. A - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. C - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. A proposed adjustment is not today's tariff - Fictional rate-case communication: a public notice describes a proposed adjustment under review; no approval or effective date is supplied.
2. A review question is not a finding of imprudence - Separate fictional regulatory briefing: reviewers request more support for a proposed cost; no conclusion about prudence has been issued.

3. An average impact is not every customer's bill - Separate fictional notice: an illustrative proposal shows an average bill increase of 6 units for a defined sample; individual account effects are not calculated.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A hearing date is not an effective date

A fictional rate-case notice lists a hearing on October 12 but gives no approval or effective date. A business association assumes new charges begin that day. Explain the distinction in a call.

Role A: Regulatory liaison: explain what the hearing date establishes and what it does not.

Role B: Association coordinator: paraphrase the distinction and ask where verified status updates will come from.

Possible opening: October 12 is the hearing date in this notice, not a stated date for new charges to begin.

Success checks

- Distinguish a review event from an effective date.
- Avoid predicting the decision.
- Agree to use verified notices for future status statements.

Add a complication: The coordinator asks whether approval immediately after the hearing is guaranteed.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Renewables Integration and Interconnection

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A project team describes an interconnection application as an approved connection. Technical and administrative reviews are still open.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: interconnection, capacity, curtailment, queue.

Model response

The application has been submitted, but the reviews are still open. I'll describe the current stage and remaining steps without implying that connection has already been authorized.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. C - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. B - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 • Conversations

1. An application is not an approved connection - Fictional renewable-project review: an interconnection application is submitted, while technical and administrative reviews remain open.
2. A preliminary study does not settle capacity - Separate fictional case: a preliminary interconnection study models one project configuration; a proposed larger configuration has not been studied.

3. A queue position is not a guaranteed date - Separate fictional project meeting: a queue record lists a project position but no confirmed connection date; the team wants to announce energization timing.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A fee receipt is mistaken for technical acceptance

A fictional developer has a receipt for an application payment but no technical review result. The project slide says technical acceptance complete. Discuss a corrected claim and the next status request.

Role A: Project analyst: explain what the receipt proves and identify the missing review result.

Role B: Development manager: challenge whether payment can reasonably be called approval.

Possible opening: The receipt confirms payment, but it doesn't establish technical acceptance of the interconnection application.

Success checks

- Separate payment from technical review.
- Retain the unknown approval status.
- Agree a request for the authorized review update.

Add a complication: The manager asks to keep approved on the slide because investors prefer a shorter label.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Asset Management and Maintenance

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

CASE

Two asset options have different purchase prices and maintenance needs. A budget slide compares only the purchase price.

Teach this move

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Vocabulary to check: asset management, condition assessment, lifecycle cost, failure rate.

Model response

The initial price is only one part of the comparison. Let's show the assumed maintenance, expected service period, and other relevant lifecycle costs so the decision reflects the full basis of the estimate.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. 'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Second-round challenge

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Language-check answers

1. B - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less. 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.
2. A - An increase of one percentage point. Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

05 · Conversations

1. Purchase price leaves out maintenance - Fictional asset comparison: option A costs 40 units plus an estimated 12 maintenance units over five years; B costs 48 plus 3. Other costs and performance are unassessed.
2. Different observation periods distort failure comparisons - Separate fictional asset review: asset group A has two failures over one year; group B has three over three years. Group sizes and operating exposure are not supplied.

3. Remote monitoring versus inspection visits - Separate fictional planning comparison: two proposed asset-monitoring packages cover the same twelve assets; A has more visits, B has remote reports. Costs and suitability await qualified review.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A shorter warranty changes the comparison

Two fictional asset quotations cover the same equipment quantity. A has a lower price and one-year warranty; B has a higher price and three-year warranty. Maintenance costs and exact warranty terms are unknown. Compare the available information without choosing a technical solution.

Role A: Procurement analyst: use matching criteria and explain the initial-cost versus stated-duration tradeoff.

Role B: Asset manager: ask which missing terms could affect lifecycle cost.

Possible opening: A has the lower purchase price, while B states a longer warranty period; the detailed terms still need review.

Success checks

- Compare the same equipment scope.
- Avoid equating warranty duration with no maintenance costs.
- Identify missing terms and maintenance information.

Add a complication: The manager calls B maintenance-free for three years based solely on its warranty duration.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Emergency Preparedness and Storm Response

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

CASE

A storm-response coordination shift has several requested resources but only some confirmed. The next coordinator needs the distinction.

Teach this move

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Vocabulary to check: mutual aid, crew staging, restoration priority, emergency response.

Model response

These resources are confirmed; the others are still requested. I've separated their status and contact points in the handoff. Please confirm receipt and update the record when an assignment changes.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence asks for an identifiable receiving team instead of leaving responsibility with an unspecified 'someone'.

Second-round challenge

The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Language-check answers

1. A - Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check. It asks for an identifiable person or team responsible for the task.
2. C - So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct? This repeats the status and responsibility and invites correction.

05 • Conversations

1. Requested crews are not confirmed crews - Fictional storm-response coordination handoff: four mutual-aid crews were requested, two confirmed, and staging details remain open; no field deployment instructions are supplied.
2. Lodging accepted, transport not arranged - Separate fictional storm-logistics case: lodging for ten support staff is confirmed, but transport from the arrival point is only requested.
3. A resource cancellation needs a receiving owner - Separate fictional coordination case: one previously confirmed support vehicle is withdrawn; a replacement is requested but unconfirmed during shift change.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 • Say it: second scenario | A staging contact is unavailable

A fictional storm-coordination plan lists a staging contact who has become unavailable. The staging arrangement itself has not been canceled, but no replacement contact has accepted. Hand over the need for an authorized reassignment.

Role A: Outgoing coordinator: distinguish the unavailable contact from the arrangement's unverified status.

Role B: Duty lead: accept the reassignment request and keep current follow-up ownership explicit.

Possible opening: The listed staging contact is unavailable, and we need a confirmed replacement before treating the handoff as accepted.

Success checks

- Avoid assuming acceptance by an unnamed replacement.
- Do not claim staging is canceled without evidence.
- Confirm ownership of the reassignment request.

Add a complication: Someone suggests assuming the named person's colleague has taken over.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Customer Programs and Energy Efficiency

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

An efficiency program reports lower energy use after installation, but weather and occupancy also changed.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: incentive, baseline, demand response, measurement and verification.

Model response

Energy use fell after installation, but weather and occupancy changed too. I'll describe the measurement basis and remaining uncertainty before attributing the entire reduction to the program.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. C - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. B - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 · Conversations

1. Lower energy use has several possible explanations - Fictional program evaluation: measured energy use fell after installation, while weather and occupancy also changed; attribution has not been established.
2. Enrollment is not demonstrated demand reduction - Separate fictional demand-response pilot: forty businesses enrolled; event participation and measured reductions have not yet been reviewed.

3. A projected saving is not a meter result - Separate fictional efficiency case: a proposal models a 10% saving, but installation has not occurred and no post-installation measurements exist.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | One month is missing from the baseline

A fictional efficiency comparison uses eleven months of baseline records against twelve months after installation. One baseline month is missing, and no adjustment is documented. Discuss what can be claimed and what the evaluation team should check.

Role A: Program analyst: identify the unequal periods and limit the current conclusion.

Role B: Program manager: ask how to describe the result without claiming verified annual savings.

Possible opening: The comparison uses different period lengths, so it doesn't yet establish verified annual savings.

Success checks

- Identify the missing month rather than invent its value.
- Avoid claiming annual savings from the unequal comparison.
- Request an appropriate evaluation of the data gap.

Add a complication: The manager suggests treating the missing month as zero use.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Executive Reliability and Investment Updates

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

A reliability presentation lists SAIDI and SAIFI without explanations. Community representatives need to understand the distinction.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: SAIDI, SAIFI, vegetation management, capital plan.

Model response

One measure summarizes average interruption duration and the other interruption frequency for the defined customer group. I'll explain both, state the reporting basis, and show what changed over the period.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. B - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. A - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. Duration and frequency answer different questions - Fictional community briefing: a slide lists SAIDI and SAIFI without definitions; values and calculation boundaries are not supplied.

2. Capital spending is not a reliability result - Separate fictional executive update: a vegetation-management investment is approved, but implementation and reliability results have not been evaluated.

3. An average can hide different customer experiences - Separate fictional reliability discussion: illustrative system-wide accumulated interruption time per customer decreases over a defined reporting period, while the report has not yet been broken down by service area.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Two reports exclude different events

Two fictional reliability slides cover the same year, but one includes a major storm and the other excludes it. Their accumulated interruption times per customer over that year differ. Explain why the comparison needs matching boundaries before attributing a performance change.

Role A: Reliability analyst: explain the difference in included events using plain English.

Role B: Executive presenter: ask how to label the slides and compare them fairly.

Possible opening: These figures include different events, so the difference isn't automatically a change in underlying performance.

Success checks

- Identify the different event boundaries.
- Avoid attributing the difference to improvement without analysis.
- Agree clear labels and a consistent comparison.

Add a complication: The presenter wants to use only the lower number without disclosing the exclusion.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

GHG Protocol: corporate standard

<https://ghgprotocol.org/corporate-standard>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-28. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Adapt a partner or class activity

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Energy and Utilities English

Professional audience: utility operations staff, energy project managers, grid planners, field supervisors, regulatory affairs teams, renewable-energy developers, customer operations teams, and infrastructure leaders

Scope: These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Lesson 01: Grid Reliability and Outage Response

Original fictional case: An outage update lists an affected area but the restoration estimate is still under assessment. A draft message gives a firm time.

Language workshop: Give a useful status update

Communication goal: Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

Language guidance: Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): We have completed ...; ... remains open. / As of ..., the status is / The next update will cover

Vocabulary: reliability: The ability to perform an intended function consistently under stated conditions over time. / feeder: An electrical distribution circuit carrying power to a local service area. / restoration: Returning a disrupted service to operation. / critical customer: A customer whose service needs receive particular operational attention under defined criteria.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: The affected area is identified, but restoration timing is still being assessed. I'll state what is confirmed and when customers should expect the next update rather than promise an unverified time.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Adapt this material for a teaching session

1. Ask me one brief planning question covering learner support needs, group size and available time. Offer a default of two B2 learners and 20 minutes. Stop and wait; use the default only if I choose it.
2. Create a timed plan using the supplied case or dialogue, its actual terminology and one narrow language goal. Include an individual first attempt, partner exchange, focused feedback and a retry. Keep the total within the time I choose. State what the learner should be able to communicate at the end.
3. Provide separate role cards for two or three professional speakers. Each card needs an objective, known information and one question to resolve. Label any invented private information as a variation; do not contradict shared facts. Do not place the model answer on the learner cards.
4. Add a B1 support option with useful frames, a B2 independent task and a C1 extension involving a plausible competing constraint. Maintain the same professional meaning across levels. Explain unfamiliar terms without removing the field's normal language. Include a workable solo alternative.
5. Put teacher notes and suggested responses in a clearly separate section after the learner material. Include likely misunderstandings and a short observation checklist for facts, clarity, tone and next step. Accept multiple successful formulations. Finish with one exit question and a delayed-recall task; identify what the teacher should check before use.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Adjust tone and register

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Energy and Utilities English

Professional audience: utility operations staff, energy project managers, grid planners, field supervisors, regulatory affairs teams, renewable-energy developers, customer operations teams, and infrastructure leaders

Scope: These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Lesson 01: Grid Reliability and Outage Response

Original fictional case: An outage update lists an affected area but the restoration estimate is still under assessment. A draft message gives a firm time.

Language workshop: Give a useful status update

Communication goal: Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

Language guidance: Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): We have completed ...; ... remains open. / As of ..., the status is / The next update will cover

Vocabulary: reliability: The ability to perform an intended function consistently under stated conditions over time. / feeder: An electrical distribution circuit carrying power to a local service area. / restoration: Returning a disrupted service to operation. / critical customer: A customer whose service needs receive particular operational attention under defined criteria.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: The affected area is identified, but restoration timing is still being assessed. I'll state what is confirmed and when customers should expect the next update rather than promise an unverified time.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Match the language to the listener

1. Choose a short message or utterance from the reference and quote it exactly. Identify its purpose and likely audience. Ask me to choose a new audience: a close colleague, a decision-maker, or an external reader who may not know the jargon. Stop and wait.
2. Ask me to adapt that message for the chosen reader, keeping its facts and degree of certainty unchanged. Offer a short frame only if I request help. Wait for my attempt before showing alternatives.
3. Discuss at most three choices in my version: directness, specialist vocabulary and interpersonal tone. Explain when a direct request is clearer than extra politeness, and when an unfamiliar abbreviation needs expansion. Avoid cultural stereotypes or claims that one nationality always communicates a certain way.
4. Show two natural alternatives, such as a concise spoken version and a more explicit written version. Explain the tradeoff in each. Do not turn a request into an order, a possibility into a promise, or a pending decision into approval.
5. Ask me to respond to one realistic follow-up from the new reader, then wait. Finish by asking me to adapt the message for a second audience without losing its core meaning. Give feedback only after the attempt.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level